LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

Why You Should Talk to Strangers

Surprising research about tiny conversations, easy phrases to start, keep going and end a chat – and Jack's bus stop story you won't forget.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 💬
Practise the phrases, try the 7-day challenge and share your answers in the comments!

0 Warm-up: Silence or chat? fun

You're on a train at 8 a.m. A stranger sits down next to you. What would **you** do?

- ☐ 📱 Sit in silence and look at my phone
- ☐ 👋 Say hello and chat a little

Guess! In a famous study, commuters guessed how many strangers would **want** to talk. What did they guess?

(a) about 10% (b) under 50% (c) about 90%

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱ 2:15**



Jack: "Silence. *Definitely* silence. It's eight in the morning!" 😴

💬 Let's talk

Answer with a partner, or say your answers out loud to yourself.

1. Do you ever chat with people you don't know? Where?

2. Do people talk to strangers at bus stops in your country?

3. Who do you see every day but barely know?

4. What's the easiest way to start a conversation, in your opinion?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Check at ⏱️ 14:17

- ☐ **1.** a stranger
- ☐ **2.** an acquaintance
- ☐ **3.** to chat
- ☐ **4.** small talk
- ☐ **5.** to strike up a conversation
- ☐ **6.** to make someone's day
- ☐ **7.** worth the wait
- ☐ **8.** a tip
- ☐ **9.** round the corner
- ☐ **10.** weak ties

a) to make someone very happy
b) a person you don't know
c) people you know only a little, like a barista or a neighbour
d) to start a conversation, often with someone you don't know
e) light, polite conversation about everyday topics
f) very close; just a short walk away
g) someone you know a little, but not well
h) a small, useful piece of advice
i) to talk in a friendly, informal way
j) good enough to wait for



Pronunciation corner 🔊 **acquaintance** = a-**QUAINT**-ance. The stress is on the second part. Say it three times: *"She's not really a friend, more of an acquaintance."*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) Talking to strangers is dangerous, so it's better to avoid it.
- (b) Tiny, friendly conversations with people we barely know can make our day better – for both people.
- (c) You need perfect English before you can talk to native speakers.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

queue · **barista** · **umbrella** · **pigeons** · **elephant** · **sourdough** · **nurse** · **envelope**

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. A "stranger" is a person…

(a) you don't know
(b) you know very well
(c) who lives with you

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

2. "It's freezing this morning, _____?"

(a) is it
(b) doesn't it
(c) isn't it

🧠 Grammar you know

3. At the <u>end</u> of a chat, it's most natural to say…

(a) Nice talking to you!
(b) Nice to meet you!
(c) Hello again!

🧠 Think about it

4. Which topic is usually <u>safe</u> for small talk?

(a) someone's salary
(b) the weather
(c) someone's religion

🧠 Common sense

5. A good way to keep a conversation going is to…

(a) look at your phone
(b) change the topic
(c) ask a follow-up question

🧠 Common sense

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. Where did the train study take place?

(a) London
(b) Toronto
(c) Chicago

🎧 ⏱️ 2:15

7. People who chatted with the barista…

(a) left in a better mood
(b) waited much longer
(c) paid less for coffee

🎧 ⏱️ 3:37

8. Before her first chat, Ana practised her sentence…

(a) twice
(b) ten times
(c) twenty times

🎧 ⏱️ 5:54

9. The man at the bakery talked to Ana about…

(a) football
(b) the weather
(c) sourdough bread

🎧 ⏱️ 5:54

10. Every morning, Jack and the woman at the bus stop said…

(a) about seven or eight words
(b) a few long sentences
(c) nothing at all

🎧 ⏱️ 19:00

🧩 **Fun fact:** In the study, **not one** person who started a chat said they were rejected.

4 True or false? listening 8 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	The Chicago study was published in 2014.	T	F	⏱️ 2:15
2	In the study, the commuters were split into two groups.	T	F	⏱️ 2:15
3	People avoided talking because conversations with strangers are unpleasant.	T	F	⏱️ 2:15
4	"Weak ties" are your closest friends and family.	T	F	⏱️ 4:36
5	On days with more little chats with weak ties, people felt happier.	T	F	⏱️ 4:36
6	In the 1973 study, many people found jobs through their close friends.	T	F	⏱️ 4:36
7	Ana came to London to study for a year.	T	F	⏱️ 5:54
8	If someone is wearing big headphones, it's polite to leave them alone.	T	F	⏱️ 7:56



5 Good moment to say hi? think 6 points

Read each situation. Tick 👍 **Go for it** or ✋ **Not now**. 🎧 Check at ⏱️ 7:56

🎧💻

1. A man is wearing big headphones and working on his laptop.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**

☕⏳

2. You're both waiting in a long queue at a café.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**

📖🚌

3. A woman is reading a book on the bus.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**

🌧️🚏

4. The bus is late and you're both waiting in the rain.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**

😢📱

5. Someone looks upset and is on the phone.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**

🐕🙂

6. Your neighbour is walking her dog and smiles at you.

☐ 👍 **Go for it** ☐ ✋ **Not now**



Lucy's tip – safe and simple: talk in public places, keep it light, and never share personal information with someone you've just met. And if someone gives short answers and turns away, that's okay. **It's not about you!**

6 Chat in the café queue

listening · 10 points

Listen to Lucy and Jack at ⏱️ 12:17. Write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer the two questions.



LUCY
Wow, it's 1 _____ today, isn't it?

JACK
I know! I think the whole 2 _____ wants coffee this morning.

LUCY
Do you come here often? Is it worth the 3 _____?

JACK
Almost every day, actually. Their cinnamon 4 _____ are amazing. You have to try one.

LUCY
Oh, really? Thanks for the 5 _____. I've never tried them.

JACK
Honestly, it'll change your life. Well, maybe your morning.

LUCY
That's good enough for me. Are you on your 6 _____ to work?

JACK
Yes, I'm a nurse at the hospital round the 7 _____. Long shift today.

LUCY
Oh, wow. Well, I hope it's a good one.

JACK
Thanks. Oh, it's my turn. Nice 8 _____ with you! Enjoy the cinnamon roll.

LUCY
You too! Have a good shift.

A. Find the little **joke** in the chat. Copy the line:

_____

B. Which **question** moves the chat from the café to Jack's life?

_____

🎭 **Say it out loud!** Read the chat with a friend – or play both parts and copy Lucy and Jack's friendly rhythm.

7 Your conversation map

phrases · 12 points

Every small conversation has three parts. Put the 12 phrases (a–l) in the right place. 🎧 Help at ⏱️ 8:47

a Anyway, I'd better get going.
b Busy today, isn't it?
c Do you take this train every day?
d I love your umbrella. Where did you get it?
e Well, this is my stop. Nice chatting with you!
f Really? How did that go?
g Have you tried the soup here? Is it good?
h That sounds interesting! Tell me more.
i Have a great day!
j How's your day going?
k Oh, where are you from?
l I should let you get back to work.

1 · START 🚦
Open the door
☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

→

2 · KEEP IT GOING 🔄
Show interest
☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

→

3 · END 👋
Leave politely
☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

SOS **When English is difficult** (⏱️ 11:13): "Sorry, I didn't quite catch that." · "Could you say that a bit more slowly?" · "Sorry, I'm still learning English. What does that word mean?"

8 Sure or not sure? ↘ ↗

pronunciation · 6 points

Question tags are the secret of small talk. Your voice tells people what you mean.

↘ Voice goes DOWN
You're **sure**. You expect "yes". Perfect for small talk!
"Lovely day, isn't it? ↘"

↗ Voice goes UP
You're **not sure**. It's a real question.
"You work here, don't you? ↗"

A. Complete the tags.

1. Terrible weather, _____ ?
2. You come here often, _____ ?
3. It wasn't very busy yesterday, _____ ?

B. Circle ↘ or ↗.

4. "Busy today, isn't it?" (You can see a long queue.) ↘ ↗
5. "You're Ana's flatmate, aren't you?" (You think so, but you're not sure.) ↘ ↗
6. "Lovely day, isn't it?" (The sun is shining.) ↘ ↗



Jack's tip: Say each sentence out loud twice: once going down ↘, once going up ↗. Can you hear how the meaning changes?

9 Say it better

common mistakes · 12 points

These sentences aren't wrong, but they sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 16:50

😐 1. "What is your job?" 😊 _____

😐 2. "I am fine, thank you, and you?" 😊 _____

😐 3. "Can I speak with you?" (to a stranger in a shop) 😊 _____

😐 4. "I must go now." 😊 _____

😐 5. "Nice to meet you!" (at the end of a chat) 😊 _____

😐 6. "The weather is very bad, yes?" 😊 _____



Did you know? "Nice to meet you" is for the **beginning**. At the **end**, say **"Nice talking to you!"** or **"It was nice to meet you."** Lots of learners mix them up!

10 Chatty idioms

idioms · 4 points

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box. Change the form if you need to. ⏱️ 14:17

break the ice · **talk someone's ear off** · **have the gift of the gab** · **Small world!**

1. At our first team meeting, Sam told a funny story to _____.
2. "You went to my school too? _____"
3. My grandmother can talk to anyone about anything. She _____.
4. The man next to me on the plane _____ for three hours!

11 Safe or tricky?

culture · 6 points

Which topics are **safe** for small talk with someone you've just met? Tick ✓ safe or ⚠️ tricky.

☀️ the weather	☐ ✓ **safe**	☐ ⚠️ **tricky**	💰 their salary	☐ ✓ **safe** ☐ ⚠️ **tricky**
⏳ the long queue	☐ ✓ **safe**	☐ ⚠️ **tricky**	🗳️ politics	☐ ✓ **safe** ☐ ⚠️ **tricky**
🎉 weekend plans	☐ ✓ **safe**	☐ ⚠️ **tricky**	🩺 their health problems	☐ ✓ **safe** ☐ ⚠️ **tricky**

🌍 Customs are different around the world – in some places, people chat at every bus stop; in others, almost never. Keep it light and watch how people react.

12 Jack's bus stop story

listening · 6 points

Listen at ⏱️ 19:00. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

- ☐ 📪 One Monday, she wasn't at the bus stop.
- ☐ ✉️ The man from the newsagent's gave Jack an envelope.
- ☐ 🌧️ On a rainy morning, Jack said, "Lovely weather, isn't it?" and she laughed.
- ☐ 💌 Jack finally learned her name: Margaret.
- ☐ 🚌 For a whole year, they said a few words every morning.
- ☐ 😟 Jack felt worried. Was she ill?

Think about it 💭 (no points) Why were those tiny chats so important for Margaret?

13 Your turn: a bus stop chat

writing · 8 points



The bus is late again. Write a short chat with the stranger next to you (2 points for each correct line).

YOU · start with a question tag 🚦

STRANGER · replies

YOU · ask a follow-up question 🔄

YOU · the bus is here! End politely 👋

✨ **Challenge:** use at least one phrase from your conversation map (Exercise 7) and one expression from Exercise 10.

Ana's one-chat-a-day challenge your mission

Ana had one short chat in English every day – and her speaking improved more than anyone's. Try it for 7 days!

Day	Mission	Who did you talk to?	How did it feel?
1	Ask a cashier or barista, "How's your day going?"		😟 🙂 😄
2	Make a comment about the weather with a question tag.		😟 🙂 😄
3	Ask someone for a recommendation.		😟 🙂 😄
4	Give a compliment about a **thing** (a bag, a dog, an umbrella).		😟 🙂 😄
5	Ask one follow-up question.		😟 🙂 😄
6	End a chat with "Nice talking to you!"		😟 🙂 😄
7	Say good morning to someone you see every day.		😟 🙂 😄

"My English didn't improve because I became more confident. I became more confident because I kept talking." – Ana

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🚦 **START**
Busy today, isn't it?
How's your day going?
Have you tried...?

🔄 **KEEP IT GOING**
Do you come here often?
Really? How did that go?
That sounds interesting!

👋 **END**
I'd better get going.
Nice talking to you!
Have a great day!

🆘 **HELP!**
Sorry, I didn't quite catch that.
Could you say that a bit more slowly?

Can you do it now?

Be honest! Tick one face for each sentence.

I can...	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
start a conversation with a comment about the situation.	😟	🙂	😄
keep a chat going with a follow-up question.	😟	🙂	😄
end a conversation politely.	😟	🙂	😄
say when I don't understand.	😟	🙂	😄
use question tags with my voice going down ↘.	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! Tell us in the comments: what's the easiest way to start a conversation with a stranger in **your** country? And do you have your own "Margaret"? We read every comment. 💜

✓ Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

b – commuters guessed that fewer than half (about 46%) of strangers would want to talk. In reality, people were happy to chat. · Predict: **elephant** 🐘 isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words

1 b · 2 g · 3 i · 4 e · 5 d · 6 a · 7 j · 8 h · 9 f · 10 c

2 · The big idea (2 points)

b

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 a · 2 c · 3 a · 4 b · 5 c · 6 c · 7 a · 8 b · 9 c · 10 a

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (three groups) · 3 F (they thought others wouldn't want to talk) · 4 F (people you know a little) · 5 T · 6 F (through acquaintances) · 7 F (six months) · 8 T

5 · Good moment to say hi?

1 ✋ · 2 👍 · 3 ✋ · 4 👍 · 5 ✋ · 6 👍

6 · Chat in the café queue

1 busy · 2 city · 3 wait · 4 rolls · 5 tip · 6 way · 7 corner · 8 chatting
A "It'll change your life. Well, maybe your morning." · B "Are you on your way to work?"

7 · Your conversation map

START: b, d, g, j · KEEP IT GOING: c, f, h, k · END: a, e, i, l

8 · Sure or not sure?

1 isn't it · 2 don't you · 3 was it · 4 ↘ · 5 ↗ · 6 ↘

9 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 What do you do (for work)? · 2 Good, thanks! How about you? · 3 Excuse me, do you mind if I ask you something? · 4 I'd better get going. / I should probably head off. · 5 Nice talking to you! / It was nice to meet you. · 6 Terrible weather, isn't it?

10 · Chatty idioms

1 break the ice · 2 Small world! · 3 has the gift of the gab · 4 talked my ear off

11 · Safe or tricky?

Safe ✓: the weather, the long queue, weekend plans · Tricky ⚠️: salary, politics, health problems

12 · Jack's bus stop story

1 🌧️ rainy morning · 2 🚌 a whole year · 3 📪 one Monday · 4 😟 worried · 5 ✉️ envelope · 6 💌 Margaret
Think about it: she was having a difficult year, and Jack's hello was the best part of many days.

13 · Your bus stop chat

Your own answers! Example: "The bus is late again, isn't it?" – "Yes, it's terrible!" – "Do you take it every day?" – "Oh, here it is! Nice talking to you." 2 points per good line.

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